

THE BUYBACK

Gracevale becomes Turraburra.

The name was written down in 1884. It took over a hundred years, and a buyback, for anyone to use it again.

In 1882, a settler named George Porter licensed the land as Charlie's Creek No. 5.

That was the first name to appear on paper.

Two years later, in 1884, a neighbouring pastoralist named Robert Christison — who had spent two decades building relationships with Dalleburra and Iningai people at his own station further north — recorded the area on a map under a different name entirely: the Terraburra clan's Country.

The right name was already written down. Nobody used it.

The station became known as Gracevale instead, and stayed Gracevale for more than a century. Porter's own son wrote memoirs about growing up on the property.

He never once mentioned the wall.

Two hundred metres of engravings, on the land his family had held for decades, and no one thought it worth a page.

For most of that century, the Iningai people whose Country it was couldn't visit the site without the property owner's permission. Cultural heritage across almost nine thousand hectares went formally unrecorded and unstudied — not because there was nothing there, but because nobody who could grant access thought to ask.

The right name was on a map before the wrong one was ever spoken. It just took longer to matter.

That changed in 2019, when the land was bought back. Within a year, cleared paddocks were under restoration, disused waterways had been reopened, and cattle numbers were down.

On the 1st of October, 2020, Gracevale was renamed and reopened as Turraburra — the name Christison had written down 136 years earlier.

At the reopening, Suzanne Thompson described the wall as “the university teaching wall of our songlines.” Not a discovery. A return.

Charlie's Creek No. 5 lasted 138 years on paper.

Terraburra was only ever missing from use.